



Android under attack!

A new Android malware affects smartphones and tablets that run on platform prior to v4.2.2. <http://dgit.in/18MCVBF>

MapmyIndia goes real-time

MapmyIndia adds real-time traffic info for Android and Windows Phone apps with its latest update. <http://dgit.in/1aZ4EmB>

Industry Connect

Design Decoded

Satish Patil – Chief Designer, User Experience – Tata Elxsi, talks to us about user-interfaces and the future of human machine interaction

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Can you briefly tell us what Tata Elxsi is all about?

Tata Elxsi is a design company that blends technology, creativity and engineering to help customers transform ideas into world-class products and solutions. We are part of the \$100 billion Tata Group and have over 4000 employees. Our key services include embedded product design, industrial design, animation, VFX and systems integration. We have four divisions: the embedded product design team, industrial design team, the visual computing labs, and systems integration division.

We leverage the expertise of all the four divisions to form our main USP of providing end-to-end support to clients across industries. Some of the industries we cater to include - communications, consumer products, defence, healthcare, media & entertainment, consumer electronics, retail & consumer goods semiconductor and transportation sectors.

According to you, what design trends can we expect in the near future?

If you observe the recent product launches, it's evident that a lot of work is happening in the "connected devices" segment across all walks of life, be it appliances or simple health monitoring products which are always internet enabled, and can freely transfer data using Bluetooth / Wi-Fi etc. Similarly "convergence" of technologies and products is getting more pronounced day by day wherein more and more devices are "interacting" with each other much more effectively.

In terms of user experience, while Multi-touch has already become common, well understood mode of interaction, new devices will continue to experiment further with voice and gesture based UI.

With improvements in display technologies, battery technologies and falling prices of hardware, in general many conventional devices will adapt "smart" operations, digitizing the interfaces.

Can you share any interesting anecdotes, or a tough challenge that your design was able to overcome?

One interesting project that we worked on was for a leading CE company to understand the usage of microwave ovens at our homes. How many of us really use those microwave ovens beyond re-heating or making noodles at home? Very few. Whereas if you ever bother to open the manual given by manufacturers it would have more than 200 "auto cook" recipes.

Ever wondered why we do not use it?

One key factor is that their UI is just too cumbersome to understand for housewives. We have been solving many such problems, be it making Microwave cooking effective or designing interfaces for consumer electronics. Due to our NDA's however I wouldn't be able to share more details on the work done.

Are you at the liberty to discuss some of the work you've executed for your clients? Our readers would love to learn any real-life, everyday machine or task that they do which is powered by a Tata Elxsi project/design.

Tata Elxsi's UX design team has helped Renesas – the world's leading suppliers of microcontrollers, to demonstrate Smart Instrument Cluster Interfaces for its reference boards capable of handling 3D graphics. While 3D HMI allowed us to take the overall experience to the next level, it was challenging to optimise the design for appropriate visual quality vis-a-vis the rendering performance for latency.

On the CE front, we have developed several innovative solutions like the



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"Smart TV" app for Panasonic Viera Connect series of TVs. The app can sync with an arm-band device using bluetooth, allowing you to monitor your daily calorie consumption and other body developments on the TV screen.

Other projects include – Developing Android based mobile applications and offering tablet based communication and media suite for some of the leading CE companies.

How does one end up being a UX designer at Tata Elxsi? Do you employ only programmers or non-tech artists? Which are the top campuses that you recruit from?

Given the fact that UX designers are expected to visualize abstract interaction and accordingly design the structures and layouts for functionalities in a logical and consistent manner, they need to have strong analytical skills, in addition to having a bent towards creativity. Additionally it always helps if they follow technology trends closely. Thus our UX team consists of people who cater to these criteria. We hire UI designers from IITs, NIDs, Srishti School of Art, Design and Technology amongst other institutes.

For the full interview with many more interesting questions and answers visit dgit.in/ddtelxsi